> such particulars as might meet the eye of an observant traveler, from the oddities of their physical features or dress to the multiplicity of strange customs by which they regulated their lives from the cradle to the grave.

Marco was supremely inquisitive, attentive to a region's geography and natural resources, birds and beasts, climate and flora, foods and drinks. He was also drawn to the local arts and crafts, and assessed their commercial value for fellow Venetians. In Marco's day, cultures were classified by religion, and so arriving in a new place, he described the locals simply as Christians, Jews, Saracens (Muslims) or 'idolaters' (catchall for Tartars, Buddhists, Hindus, Jains and others). He admired hard-working, law-abiding people, and criticized indolent, unruly ones. There are hardly any personal incidents in the book. What makes his account truly worthwhile are his vignettes of social life, such as how the Tartars pitch their tents or go to war, how some Central Asians extract musk from gazelles, how a girl's virginity in Cathay is verified before marriage, why men in a Tibetan province prefer to take as wives women with lots of prior sexual experience, or how the Great Khan's 'admirably contrived' postal service works.

Marco was no scholar, however, and had scant interest in history, philosophy or language (unlike, say, Alberuni, the Persian traveller to India in the early eleventh century). Marco was a pious Christian and admired other cross-cultural expressions of piety. He believed in magic, incantations and the power of astrologers to 'bring on tempests and thunderstorms when they wish and stop them at any time'. He uses superlatives too readily and is prone to wild exaggeration (for example, he claims the city of Hangzhou has 12,000 bridges, the Great Khan goes hunting with 10,000 falconers, and every tree on the 7448 islands in the China Sea gives off 'a powerful and agreeable fragrance'). He was gullible too, lending credence to hearsay about giant birds that lift up elephants, men with tails as thick as a dog's and a legendary Christian king of Asia called Prester John (were some of these Rustichello's embellishments?). He could also be very naive about human relationships, relying too much on surface appearances. For instance, he claims that the multiple wives of Tartar chieftains live together happily, with no conflict whatsoever.

In Ceylon, he relates the story of the Buddha with admiration, adding that 'had he been Christian, he would have been a great saint with our Lord